

Usability Study | Petitions Workflow

US Tax Court, Washington D.C.
March 2019

Study Information

In this study, Flexion UX Designers tested the Petitions QC Workflow in a development environment for the first time. Previously, the team conducted several iterative design studies with Petitions Clerks using Figma wireframes.

Participants

- 3 Petitions Clerks
- 1 Petitions Supervisor

Sessions

- On-site at the US Tax Court offices in Washington D.C.
- Individual, in-person sessions with a Flexion UX Designer
- Each session lasted approximately one hour

Equipment

- Up-to-date Windows desktop computers and monitors provided by the Court
- Tests conducted with Chrome 100% zoom (3), IE 120% zoom (1)

Summary of Key Findings

Are Petitions Clerks able to perform their QC process using the new designs?

- ✅ Overall, participants were able to locate, assign, access, review, transcribe or correct, save, send, validate, and recall petitions with ease and most aspects of the system worked as they expected.
- 😞 Participants experienced varying degrees of difficulty understanding the tabbed navigation design on the Work Queues and both levels of QC Form tabs.

Are the field labels and case type choices understandable?

- ✅ Field labels were clear and familiar with no issues noted.

How are users interacting with the designs in general?

- 💖 “I LIKE THIS!” - Participants really enjoyed the one page layout and felt that it would be a significant day-to-day improvement for them.
- 💖 “THAT’S DOPE!” - Bonus! One Participant loved the “Start a Case” form for petitioners.

Findings | Petitions Work Queues

Content

Findings

- 😊 Participants expressed or indicated that the queues provided all required info.
- 😞 Some participants wanted a separate box for served petitions for clarity.
- 😞 One participant tried on several occasions to use the Section Queue “Sent” box to verify which petitions they had assigned and to whom; they expressed that unassigned, assigned, batched, served, and other messages are distinct items which she needs to see separately.

Recommendations

- 💡 Consider a method for displaying unassigned, assigned, batched, served, and other messages separately to support easier and faster scanning and searching, such as automated sorting, on-demand sorting, filtering, and/or separate queue boxes.

Navigation

Findings

- 😊 Participants understood the “Inbox” and “Sent” concept.
- 😞 One participant did not seem to realize the queue labels were clickable and eventually worked both petitions directly from the Section Queue.
- 😞 Several participants repeatedly clicked on the docket number in the work queue.
- 😞 Several participants did not seem to notice the work item messages, often double-clicking on non-linked text which invoked and immediately hid the message.

Recommendations

- 💡 Consider altering the tab design to clearly indicate they are interactive.
- 💡 Consider altering the queue message style so they are more visible and accessible.
- 📌 Training will also help address any confusion regarding the different work queues.

System Communication

Findings

- 🙄 One participant was not confident if the assignment they made to another person was successful. They asked for a message that indicates the selected petitions have been successfully assigned from the Section Queue and confirm the assignee.
- 🙄 One participant expressed that it could be challenging to see what kinds of work items are in their queue. They asked for type indicators like “review,” so they can easily scan, sort, and prioritize their work.

Recommendations

- 💡 Consider a success message after petitions have been assigned to indicate the action was completed as expected.
- 💡 Consider adding message type indicators to facilitate fast, easy work prioritization.

Findings | Petition Transcription and QC

Layout

Findings

- 😊 Participants had no issues with the dual panels and were able to scroll both panels to compare the QC Form and PDF.
- 💖 Some participants expressed how much they liked having everything on one screen because using dual monitors can be painful over time.

Navigation

Findings

-  Several participants did not interact with the Case Info or Notice tabs on the QC Form without a prompt from the facilitator. Either they did not notice the tabs or did not recognize that it was part of the transcription workflow.
-  Participants move through the QC Form fields using a mix of mouse and tab key.

Recommendation

-  Consider altering QC tab style to draw more attention to the navigation and workflow.

Error Handling

Findings

- 😊 Field-level error handling was useful for the one participant who encountered it.
- 📌 Some participants encountered page-level error handling but seemed to ignore it unless prompted by a facilitator. In later interviews, we learned that Court Staff are often inundated with miscellaneous errors from the current system and have become desensitized to them or learned to ignore them.

PDF Viewer

Findings

- 🙄 Several participants demonstrated or expressed difficulty with the small text on the PDF and could not find a way to zoom in.
- 🙄 One participant felt the PDF documentation was out of order and expressed a need to rearrange the pages to make it right. (Reference: demonstration docket 118)

Recommendations

- 💡 A zoom tool does exist in the PDF viewer but it is hard to find and can be challenging to use. It would be better to have a zoom tool located in the viewer's top toolbar.
- 📌 Investigate petition package page order. If needed, consider providing a way to rearrange the PDF pages within the UI. Alternatively, provide a way to download, alter, and replace the petition package.

Parties

Findings

- 🙄 One participant felt that three address lines added clutter to the QC Form.
- 😞 One participant expressed a preference for one address when spouses are living together or a “same as above” feature to minimize labor required for duplicate entry.
- 😊 The same participant felt separate addresses for spouses living apart was helpful.

Recommendations

- 💡 Consider displaying the minimum the number of address lines required for a pre-entered address or one address line for paper petitions, and provide the ability to “add a line” for longer, more complex addresses such as business or prison addresses.
- 💡 Provide a way for Petitioners and Clerks to link addresses for spouses living together or “add a new address” for spouses living apart.

Case Information

Findings

- 😊 Participants were familiar with the case types and descriptions.
- 😞 Participants needed to add multiple amounts for one tax year.
- 😞 One participant expected changes to update the caption automatically.

Recommendations

- ✅ [Planned] Add applicable fields for amounts and fees.
- 🕒 [Descoped] Dynamic captioning after the initial petition submission was descoped due to complexity. Post-MVP, consider adding dynamic captioning throughout the petition life-cycle and provide an explicit caption override control when deviation from the formula is necessary.

Orders

Findings

- 🙄 Some participants felt strongly about specifying a party for ratification orders. Information regarding digital signatures was provided by the facilitator, however participants expressed lingering concern with ambiguity.
- 🙄 One user believed the order checkboxes would auto generate orders.

Recommendation

- 💡 Co-locate the ratification order checkbox with the second party on the Parties tab for better context and clarity when considering and requesting ratification orders.
- 💡 Automate order generation for parity between the new and current systems.

Save and Send

Findings

- 😊 All participants used the save button and felt that it worked as expected.
- 😊 Participants felt the “Send to IRS” process worked as expected.
- 📌 Some participants needed reassurance that the demo wouldn’t actually send anything!

Review and Recall

Findings

- 😊 One participant expressed that they really liked the read-only petition view and thought it was helpful. They expressed how easy it was to scan and check their work.
- 😊 All participants recalled their petition and expressed that it worked as expected.
- 😞 One participant expressed a strong preference for showing the editable fields immediately upon recalling to act faster and with less hassle.
- 😐 Several participants felt inclined to locate their sent petitions and most were able to locate them in their Sent box without assistance.

Recommendations

- ✅ [Planned] Revise the recall flow to display the editable QC Form after recall.
- 💡 Consider an “edit now” or “send to [user] / myself” option for the recall flow.

Findings | Other

Waivers

Findings

- 🙄 One participant expressed concern regarding the omission of a checkbox for a Denial of Waiver Order and wondered how a Clerk would attach and transcribe Waivers from paper petition packages. The participant expressed further concern that if Petitioners are not able to submit a Request for Waiver at the time of filing, individuals who can't afford the fee may choose not to file at all. Participant would like Petitioners to be informed about Waivers, determine their eligibility, and attach a waiver.

Recommendations

- 🕒 [Hold for #430] Include fields to upload and transcribe Waivers on QC Form.
- 🕒 [Hold for #430] Provide information on all payment options prior / during e-filing.

Payments

Findings

-  One Participant expressed interest in Petitioners specifying how they expect to pay the filing fee (check, ePay, waiver) at the time of e-filing. Participant does **not** want them to be able to upload a copy of a check or supply check information because copies of checks are often sent with paper petitions but the originals never arrive.

Recommendations

-  [Hold for #430] Consider prompting petitioners for how they intend to pay.

Paper Petitions

Findings

-  The Petitions Supervisor expects clerks to scan a paper petition, upload it, then transcribe / QC the petition from the QC Form. She explains that it's better for Clerks to QC on the screen because looking up and down to enter data from the paper petition could cause neck strain. She does not expect a different clerks to QC a transcribed paper petition because it adds too much time and complication.

Recommendation

-  [Pending #311] Permit Clerks to upload scanned petitions to the system and transcribe from the existing QC Form for faster and more ergonomic workflow.
-  Facilitate scanning paper documents directly to the UI.

Recommendations | Plan of Action

Coming Up

To be added to #1171 QC Clean Up

- Add applicable fields for amounts and fees.
- Revise the recall flow to display the editable QC Form after recall.

Pending #311 Paper Petitions

- Permit Clerks to upload scanned petitions to the system and transcribe from the existing QC Form for faster and more ergonomic workflow.

Hold for #430 Online Payment of Filing Fee

- Include fields to upload and transcribe Waivers on QC Form.
- Provide information on all payment options prior / during e-filing.
- Consider prompting petitioners for how they intend to pay.

Special Handling

Investigate

- Does petition page order matter? If needed, consider providing a way to rearrange the PDF pages within the UI. Alternatively, provide a way to download, alter, and replace the petition package.
- A zoom tool does exist in the PDF viewer but it is hard to find and can be challenging to use. It would be better to have a zoom tool located in the viewer's top toolbar. Can we change the existing functionality?

Special Ops Team

- Automate order generation for parity between the new and current systems.
- Can / should we facilitate scanning paper documents directly to the UI?

Consider for MVP

Work Queues

- Alter the Work Queue tab designs to draw attention to navigation and workflow.
- Alter the queue message style so they are more visible and accessible.
- Provide a success message after petitions have been assigned indicating completion as expected.
- Provide a method for displaying unassigned, assigned, batched, served, and other messages separately to support easier and faster scanning and searching, such as automated sorting, on-demand sorting, filtering, and/or separate queue boxes.
- Add message type indicators (such as “Review”) to facilitate fast, easy work prioritization.

QC Form

- Alter the QC tab designs to draw attention to navigation and workflow.
- Co-locate the ratification order checkbox with the second party on the Parties tab for better context and clarity when considering and requesting ratification orders.

Consider for Post-MVP

QC Form

- Dynamic captioning after the initial petition submission was descope due to complexity.
Post-MVP, consider adding dynamic captioning throughout the petition life-cycle and provide an explicit caption override control when deviation from the formula is necessary.
- Provide a way for Petitioners and Clerks to link addresses for spouses living together or “add a new address” for spouses living apart.
- Consider displaying the minimum the number of address lines required for a pre-entered address or one address line for paper petitions, and provide the ability to “add a line” for longer, more complex addresses such as business or prison addresses.
- Consider an “edit now” or “send to [user] / myself” option for the recall flow.

Questions | Come on, let us have 'em!

Additional Information | Screen Shots